INTERPERSONAL FALSE BELIEF #53 · FORGIVING OTHERS

“I can't forgive until I feel like forgiving.”

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Where it often comes from

We assume forgiveness is an emotion, a warm feeling that arrives on its own. When the pain stays, we conclude we have not forgiven and may feel stuck or guilty. Waiting for the feeling can delay healing for years.

What Scripture teaches

Paul commands, “Bear with one another and forgive any complaint you may have against someone else. Forgive as the Lord forgave you.” Jesus said, “When you stand to pray, if you hold anything against another, forgive it.” Forgiveness is spoken of as a decision and an action. Feelings often follow, sometimes slowly. Jesus tells us to “love your enemies, do good to those who hate you, bless those who curse you, pray for those who mistreat you,” which are acts we can do before the feeling arrives. David prayed, “Create in me a clean heart, O God, and renew a right spirit within me.” We can ask God to change our hearts as we choose obedience.

> *“Bear with one another and forgive any complaint you may have against someone else. Forgive as the Lord forgave you”* (Colossians 3:13).

Also see

> “And when you stand to pray, if you hold anything against another, forgive it, so that your Father in heaven will forgive your trespasses as well” (Mark 11:25).

> “Be kind and tenderhearted to one another, forgiving each other just as in Christ God forgave you” (Ephesians 4:32).

> “Create in me a clean heart, O God, and renew a right spirit within me” (Psalm 51:10).

> “But to those of you who will listen, I say: Love your enemies, do good to those who hate you, bless those who curse you, pray for those who mistreat you” (Luke 6:27–28).

Common self-statements

- I do not feel forgiving, so I cannot.
- If it were real forgiveness, the pain would be gone.
- I am still angry, so I have not forgiven.
- I am waiting until my heart is ready.
- Forcing it would be fake.
- I cannot choose how I feel.

Common logical errors

- Emotional reasoning: Treating feelings as the measure of forgiveness.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing forgiveness is either complete or absent.
- Should statements: Insisting that I should feel peaceful first.
- Perfectionism: Expecting forgiveness to be complete in one step.

Challenging questions

- What is the difference between a decision to forgive and a feeling of forgiveness?
- What small action could I take that is consistent with forgiveness?

- Has a feeling ever followed a choice in other areas of my life?
- What am I waiting for before I start?
- How can I ask God to change my heart?
- Who can pray with me?

Truth summary

> Forgiveness begins as a decision, with feelings following over time. I can choose to release the debt, pray for the person, and ask God to change my heart. I do not have to wait for a feeling.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Forgiveness
- Forgive
- Prayer, How to
- Hatred
- Anger

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Anger
- Prayer

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Amazing Grace My Chains Are Gone — Chris Tomlin
Salvation and freedom come through grace rather than earning acceptance.

Forgiveness — Matthew West
Ask God for help releasing resentment while working through real hurt.

All Things New — Steven Curtis Chapman
God's renewing work offers hope beyond failure, decay, and loss.

Amazing Grace — Reawaken Hymns
This classic hymn locates salvation and sustaining hope in grace rather than merit.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I can't forgive until I feel like forgiving"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I can't forgive until I feel like forgiving." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What is the decision I can make?
- ☐ What small act can I take?
- ☐ What am I waiting for?
- ☐ Whom can I pray for?
- ☐ Who can pray with me?
- ☐ How can I renew my choice?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Forgiveness is a decision.
- ☐ Feelings often follow choices.
- ☐ I can pray for those who hurt me.
- ☐ God can renew my heart.
- ☐ Forgiveness can be a process.
- ☐ I can start today.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Colossians 3:13
  "Bear with one another and forgive any complaint you may have against someone else. Forgive as the Lord forgave you."
- ☐ Mark 11:25
  "And when you stand to pray, if you hold anything against another, forgive it, so that your Father in heaven will forgive your trespasses as well."
- ☐ Psalm 51:10
  "Create in me a clean heart, O God, and renew a right spirit within me."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Choice and feeling: Each day, record one act of forgiveness (a prayer, a release) and any change in feeling.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Colossians 3:13 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I forgive as the Lord forgave me, even before the feeling comes.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Forgive" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Say the decision. Pray, "I choose to forgive [name], and I ask You to change my heart."
- [ ] Pray for them. Ask God to bless them for a week.
- [ ] Repeat as needed. Renew the decision when feelings flare up.
- [ ] Find a prayer partner. Ask a friend to pray with you.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I can't forgive until I feel like forgiving": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A choice made
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I can't forgive until I feel like forgiving.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I do not feel forgiving, but I choose to forgive. Create in me a clean heart, change my feelings in Your time, and help me release what I carry. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.